

CREATING PERSONAS FOR TECHNICAL WRITING



STEP 1: IDENTIFY YOUR AUDIENCE SEGMENTS

Start by identifying the different types of users who will interact with your documentation.

Example: If you're writing documentation for a software product, your audience segments might include "New Users," "Advanced Users," "IT Administrators," and "Support Staff."



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STEP 2: CONDUCT USER RESEARCH

Gather data about your audience segments through surveys, interviews, and analytics. Understand their goals, challenges, and how they typically interact with your product or service.

Example: Interview a few IT Administrators to learn about their specific pain points and what they look for in documentation, such as troubleshooting guides or setup instructions.



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STEP 3: DEFINE PERSONA CHARACTERISTICS

Create detailed descriptions for each persona, including demographic information, job roles, skill levels, and specific needs.

Example:

- Persona Name: "Jane, the New User"
- Role: Marketing Professional
- Skill Level: Beginner with technical tools
- Needs: Clear, step-by-step instructions with visuals for setting up and using the software.



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STEP 4: OUTLINE PERSONA GOALS AND CHALLENGES

For each persona, define what they aim to achieve with your product and what challenges they face.

Example:

- Goal: "Jane" wants to learn how to create marketing reports using the software quickly.
- Challenge: She is not familiar with technical jargon and needs simple, jargon-free instructions.



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STEP 5: CREATE SCENARIO-BASED USE CASES

Develop scenarios that depict how each persona would use your product, guiding the content you need to create.

Example: For "Jane," a scenario might involve her trying to generate her first marketing report. The documentation should include a clear, easy-to-follow guide on how to do this from start to finish.



STEP 6: ALIGN DOCUMENTATION WITH PERSONA NEEDS

Use the personas to tailor your content, ensuring that it meets the specific needs and preferences of each user type.

Example: For "Jane," the documentation should include lots of visuals, straightforward language, and clear, numbered steps. For an "IT Administrator," the content might be more detailed and technical, focusing on configuration settings and advanced troubleshooting.



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STEP 7: REVIEW AND ITERATE

Regularly review your personas and update them based on feedback and changes in your audience's needs. Adjust your documentation accordingly.

Example: If feedback shows that "Jane" struggles with understanding certain steps, simplify the language further or add additional visual aids.

